This data will probably lead to even more questions, but by now you should get the idea. Rarely do you start off with all the questions that lead you to where you want to go, but spending time exploring your data to see how things are related will help you determine what to track.

7.3.2. Step 2: break it down—determine what to track

Having a big data mine is great, but sometimes it's tough to figure out what data points to watch. After exploring your data (a habit that can be very addictive), you should start to get an idea of what data points speak most to how your team works. If you have a small team, whose members sit next to each other, having a high number of comments on PTS tickets probably indicates a communication problem, but if you have teams in multiple geographic locations, it could indicate great cross-team communication. If your team doesn't comment on tickets because they sit next to each other and discuss issues, then that data point may never move and therefore will be of no use to you. If yours is a globally distributed team that uses comments to push things forward, then that data point will be extremely important to you.

A productive way to get to the bottom of what you want to track is to build a mind map that helps you identify the questions you're trying to answer. Follow these steps:

1. Ask the question.
2. Think of all the dimensions of the answer.
3. Note where you can obtain data to get your answer.

Using the scenario in section 7.2.1, the team would have created the mind map shown in figure 7.10. Another example of breaking down a big question into smaller, measureable chunks is shown in figures 7.11 and 7.12, which illustrate how to check if your team is estimating accurately.

Figure 7.10. Breaking down how to measure teamwork with a mind map